Chapter Forty-Nine

The Splintering Khanate

Between 1246 and 1264,
the Mongols spread their conquests
from east to west,
but then watch the empire divide into four

In 1246, the Mongol clan leaders assembled at Sira-ordu, a few miles away from Karakorum, and finally hailed Guyuk as Great Khan.

It had taken Guyuk, the oldest son of Ogodei, four years to reach this peak. After Ogodei's death in 1242, his widow Toregene had insisted on Guyuk's election. But a healthy segment of the Mongol chiefs preferred another grandson of Genghis Khan: Mongke, the oldest son of Genghis's youngest son Tolui.

By this point, all of Genghis Khan's own sons were dead. Jochi had died before his father; Tolui had drunk himself to death in 1232; Chagatai had died just a few months before Ogodei himself. Three grandsons stood in line for the succession: Mongke, Guyuk, and Batu in the west, the oldest son of the oldest son.

Guyuk was widely unpopular, in part because his father had disliked him and had repeatedly suggested that the succession pass him by. But as regent until a new khan was elected, his mother Toregene had the force of Mongol law behind her; and the Mongols, ruthless in battle, were just as unbending